Remote Work: What Actually Happened

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Look, I'll be honest — when my boss first floated the remote work idea back in 2019, I laughed. Literally laughed, right in his face. Sorry, Tom.

Our office on 7th Street was this chaotic, noisy, beautiful mess. Dogs under desks. That one weird printer that only worked on Tuesdays. Jenny's plants slowly dying in the break room because she kept 'forgetting' to water them (we all knew she hated those plants).

Then March 2020 happened. You know the story. Suddenly we were all home, Zoom-ing each other with bad lighting and unflattering webcam angles. My cat walked across my keyboard during a client pitch. Twice.

But here's the thing nobody warned me about — I got WAY more work done. Not some marginal improvement either. I mean, I finished a three-week project in nine days. Partly because nobody was stopping by my desk to ask about the weekend. Partly because I could finally concentrate.

Not everyone had it easy though. Marcus, bless him, had two kids under five and no dedicated workspace. He took calls from his closet for six months. We all heard it when Ethan threw a tantrum about the wrong-colored juice box. Marcus still won employee of the year somehow.

The weird part? When we eventually went back — hybrid, three days in office — it felt off. The office had changed. Half the plants were dead (thanks Jenny). The Tuesday printer was gone. People didn't really chit-chat anymore. It's like we forgot how.

I think the honest truth is this: remote work broke something about how we worked together, AND fixed something about how we got things done. Both can be true. Anyone telling you it's all good or all bad is selling something.

My take, two years in? I'd never go fully back. But I'd also never go fully remote. Two days a week with Tom and the team, three days with my cat — that's the sweet spot for me. Your mileage may vary, as the nerds say.